

ALL EYES ON ESPORTS WORLD CUP

Nihal Sarin will be one of the two Indians in chess at the Esports World Cup, with the other being Arjun Erigaisi.

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India's golden era in chess has already seen D.Gukesh and Divya Deshmukh become the World Champion and the World Cup winner respectively. The success has now extended into avenues of esports, with Nihal Sarin securing a spot in the finals of online chess at the Esports World Cup (EWC) 2025. He was one of only four players — and the sole Indian — to qualify for the global tournament through the Last Chance Qualifiers (LCQ), completing the 16-player roster for the EWC group stage, which begins on July 29 in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia.

The Indian grandmaster registered five wins, finishing with 5.5 points to secure a top-four spot in Group B and advance to the playoffs. In the knockouts, he pulled off a stunning comeback against Belarus' Denis Lazavik in the Round of 16, delivering a checkmate from a losing position to clinch a 1.5-0.5 victory.

He followed it up with a 1.5-0.5 win against Dutch star Anish Giri in the quarters. Sarin then sealed his qualification by defeating Russia's Andrey Esipenko

- 2.5-1.5 in the winners' bracket.
- India now has two of its most promising chess players at the EWC: Sarin (representing S8UL) and Arjun Erigaisi, who qualified through the Champions Chess Tour (playing for Gen.G Esports).
- "I'm incredibly happy to have qualified for the Esports World Cup 2025. The competition was intense, and the format tested every aspect of my game. I'm thankful to S8UL for believing in me and supporting me on this journey," Sarin said.
- "I'm now looking forward to making the country proud on the main stage."
- Sarin is currently ranked eighth in India and 37th in the world with a FIDE rating of 2692. He will join 15 of the world's top chess players, including Magnus Carlsen, Hikaru Nakamura, Fabiano Caruana, Nodirbek Abdusattorov and Alireza Firouzja at the EWC main event.
- The tournament has a prize pool of a whopping USD 1.5 million (approx. ₹12.9 crore) and will follow a rapid 10+0 time control format.

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